

The importance of accident investigators' work was underlined by a notorious case in which their findings were not sufficiently heeded. A report into a near-fatal incident involving a DC-10 in Detroit in 1972 indicated that the aircraft's cargo door represented a hazard, since it could appear to be securely locked when it was not. Two years later a DC-10 flying from Paris to London crashed into the forest of Ermenonville, killing all 346 people on board – the first wide-body jet crash and the worst air accident at that date. Investigation revealed that once again the

cargo door had not been securely fastened and had disastrously burst open at an altitude of 11,500ft (3,500m). An official report later concluded that the “risks had already become evident 19 months earlier... but no efficacious corrective action had followed.”

In our heavily armed and deeply divided world, the hazards of flight include military action. Such disasters can be purely accidental, as when an airliner was shot down over the Black Sea by a stray Ukrainian missile during military exercises in 2001. But they are more likely to be deliberate acts committed in an atmosphere of tension and paranoia. As early as 1955, an El Al Constellation that inadvertently crossed the Iron Curtain into Bulgarian airspace was shot down by interceptors. In 1973 a Libyan Boeing 727 that strayed over the Sinai desert – part of Egypt but then occupied by Israel – was brought down by Israeli interceptors, killing 106 people. Ten years later a Korean Air Lines 747, Flight 007, inexplicably wandered into Soviet airspace

on a night trip from Anchorage in Alaska to Seoul in South Korea, and was shot down by a Sukhoi Su-15 with air-to-air missiles. All 269 people on board were killed. During a tense period in the Gulf in 1988, the US Navy cruiser *Vincennes* shot down an Iran Air Airbus with a SAM missile, killing 286 people, after somehow interpreting the radar profile of a scheduled airline flight as that of a jet fighter on an attack mission.

Hijacking

Such actions on the part of regular armed forces have been rare, however, compared with the depredations of hijackers and terrorists. From the start hijacking was encouraged by an often ambivalent attitude of many states to the perpetrators. The phenomenon began in the 1950s with individuals escaping from communist-ruled Eastern Europe – three airliners were hijacked from Czechoslovakia to West Germany on a single day. The hijackers received a hero's



DAWSON'S FIELD HIJACKING

Hijacked by Palestinian terrorists en route from Bahrain to London in September 1970, a BOAC Vickers VC-10 waits on the desert airstrip at Dawson's Field in Jordan, while negotiations decide the fate of the aircraft, passengers, and crew.



SYMBOLIC DESTRUCTION

The Palestinian terrorists begin the destruction of the three airliners they had hijacked to Dawson's Field – a VC-10, a Boeing 707, and a Douglas DC-8. With their crew and passengers removed, the airliners were “sacrificed” as symbols of Western technology and capitalism.